

Tap the app: Be smart, Be Healthy!

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Being healthy and fit is no longer a hypothesis. It is as real as real can get. And if you think smart phones are just another fashion accessory, think again! Health and technology, the twin social interest icons continue an enviable run in an exploding app market. It's like having the wealth of health in your pockets.

With thousands of apps trending the mobile market, there is very little scope for reflection on how some of these apps are having a major share of space in our lifestyle. Given the structure of our lives, it has become essential to keep up with the demands of a fast-paced life. And here is where the healthcare apps come into picture. For example, apps focusing on running, gym, diet, certain health-specific conditions are becoming increasingly popular and necessary. Healthcare apps are used, perhaps periodically, by large numbers of people. "I do find that IF I want to lose weight, true monitoring of calories is really critical. Fitocracy is fun because I can see my weight lifting progress, and it's somewhat addictive trying to gather trophies for various lifting skills (personal competition)," says Scott Moeller, Ph.D., Network Systems Engineer with TrellisWare Technologies, Inc., San Diego. Dr. Moeller also feels that the app market opportunities have exploded, as there is a relatively low cost to entry and a wider availability of customer base. Where there is dollars to be made (and this is a big market), corporations will pile in trying to enlarge their slice of the pie.

That's a major sales point up-front, and these companies know it. It's the advantage they have over "old" off-the-shelf products, plus they can be low-cost and low-barrier to "try it out". There is a lot of competition to provide a useful product. It takes less effort to monitor certain habits using healthcare apps (e.g., Myfitnesspal allows barcode scanning, remembers common meals, etc.). This probably has interesting market considerations for healthcare app producers. If you are a one-time paid app developer, you care more about drawing people in for one purchase than you do about providing a quality product with good support. Meanwhile, if you are a pay-per-month healthcare app (or advertising based) developer, then you do care about maintaining customers, and you are at the disadvantage of being in a non-sticky market. The thing is, healthcare is not a very sticky topic for most people. They become concerned with it during fits and spurts, but many people do not stick to it for long durations. You probably stuck to your Gmail account from day one, because it was fun and provided you with clean communications with your friends. But healthcare is hard, and people often lack the focus to stick with it. Echoing a slightly different refrain is Amitabha Ghosh, Ph.D., a scientist working with a Los Angeles based research firm, who started putting in more miles when he chanced upon Runtastic and MapMyRun. "I love my fresh breath of air in the mornings. What better way to look forward to it than having an app which pushes you hard, monitors your track record, and sets newer goals so you become your own competitor?" Based on his collaboration with Dr. Murray Brown, Psychiatrist, at the Veteran Affairs, Los Angeles, he thinks that medical professionals as well as family members of patients with chronic post traumatic stress disorder (PTSD) syndrome can immensely improve their health practices by using an app that is able to track the mental health of those veterans on a regular basis.

About 95 million Americans used their smart phones either as healthcare tools or to find health information, according to a survey of more than 8,600 adults released in October by Manhattan Research, a New York-based healthcare marketing research firm. Most of the consumer healthcare apps were "simple in design and do little more than provide information," according to the IMS report. Only 159 of the consumer apps could track or capture user-entered data, and fewer than 50 relate to condition management or provide tools and calculators for users to measure their vitals. That leaves "considerable room for growth in this sector," the report said. No wonder 2014 kick started with some hottest apps like Hot5, Gympact, Runkeeper, Weight Watchers Mobile, Runkeeper, Zombies, Run! 2.